Identifying and supporting educators' EMI development needs

Practical guide for institutions | I04

Identify what educators need to teach their subjects effectively through English, then connect those needs to appropriate support. Consider English-language proficiency, teaching practice and working conditions separately, while recognising that they may interact.

EMI development should address both language proficiency and teaching practice. Educators with strong English may still need support to adapt their teaching, while experienced educators may need targeted language development for particular teaching tasks.

Using this guide: Build this work into existing staff development and teaching-support processes. Make its developmental purpose explicit. Where formal proficiency assessment or performance review is required, explain its purpose, criteria and relationship to this process.

1. Start with educators' teaching tasks

Invite educators to identify tasks they find demanding, such as:

- Explaining disciplinary concepts and responding to unexpected questions.
- Giving instructions and checking understanding.
- Facilitating discussions involving varied English-language backgrounds.
- Writing assessment briefs, criteria and feedback.
- Supporting ethnic-minority students' participation.

Include strengths and successful approaches as well as difficulties. Do not assume development needs from an educator's accent, nationality or first language.

2. Review relevant evidence collaboratively

Use selected teaching materials, educator reflection and agreed peer observation or rehearsal to explore the difficulty.

For example, review an assignment brief together or ask the educator to rehearse an explanation of a complex concept. Agree beforehand what feedback is wanted, who will see it and how it will be used.

Student feedback can identify experiences worth exploring, but should not be treated as a diagnosis of an educator's language proficiency.

3. Distinguish the type of support needed

Explore whether the difficulty primarily concerns:

- English-language development: expressing relationships precisely, understanding questions or communicating spontaneously.
- Teaching practice: sequencing explanations, designing participation or checking understanding.

- Knowledge of students' linguistic contexts: recognising ethnic-minority languages and avoiding assumptions about Vietnamese proficiency.
- Working conditions: preparation time, class size, resources or access to specialist advice.

More than one response may be needed. General English training alone will not address every teaching difficulty.

Include communication strategies explicitly: paraphrasing an explanation, checking shared meaning, asking for clarification and responding to unexpected questions. Practise these within relevant subject teaching tasks.

4. Agree on a practical development plan

Choose one or two priorities linked to upcoming teaching. Specify what the educator will practise, what support will be provided and when progress will be reviewed.

For example: "Prepare and rehearse an explanation of the next engineering process, using accurate subject terms, clear stages and checks of student understanding."

Agree on realistic time and workload arrangements. Development should be supported through institutional provision rather than added as an undefined personal responsibility.

5. Provide clear pathways into support

Identify contacts and access arrangements for:

- English-language development relevant to teaching tasks.
- Individual consultation with a language specialist.
- EMI teaching development, coaching or mentoring.
- Peer rehearsal, observation and communities of practice.
- Advice on inclusive multilingual teaching and referral processes.

Educators should not be expected to learn students' ethnic-minority languages as a condition of providing inclusive teaching. They do need guidance on recognising those languages, allowing appropriate use and arranging ways to check meaning when necessary.

6. Review progress and address remaining barriers

Review an agreed teaching task or material and discuss what changed. Consider educator reflection, peer feedback and evidence of students' understanding.

Adjust the plan where necessary. If the main barrier is unavailable support, inadequate preparation time or inaccessible resources, assign institutional action rather than repeatedly referring the educator for training.

7. Example responding to unexpected questions

An educator explains prepared material clearly but finds unexpected questions difficult to follow and answer in English.

A discussion with a peer and language specialist identifies two priorities: practising clarification language and structuring short responses. The educator rehearses questions drawn from their subject and uses phrases that check the question before answering.

The program provides consultation time and arranges a follow-up. The educator also introduces a written question route so that students have another way to raise questions. This complements continuing language development.

8. Review checklist

☐ Educators contribute to identifying their development priorities.

☐ Evidence relates to actual teaching tasks.

☐ Language, pedagogy and working conditions are considered.

☐ Development plans identify support, time and review points.

☐ Educators know how to access relevant provision.

☐ Institutional barriers lead to institutional action.

9. When further provision is needed

Arrange specialist language assessment or sustained development where language difficulties continue to affect essential teaching tasks despite appropriate initial support. Any formal assessment should use a suitable process with clearly communicated criteria. Short workshops or informal peer support should not be assumed sufficient for every need.

10.Related toolkit guidance

I01: designing and reviewing EMI programs. I02: identifying student language and learning support needs. D01–D03: instructions, vocabulary and explanations. D06–D08: participation, questions and group work. D18–D19: checking meaning and inclusive multilingual learning.

11.Supporting sources

Galloway, N., & Sahan, K. (2021). An investigation into English Medium Instruction in higher education in Thailand and Vietnam. British Council. Open source

Section 9, “Teacher recruitment and training” (printed p. 42), discusses training responsive to EMI educators’ needs, collaboration between subject and language specialists, and pedagogical preparation. “Establishment of a community of practice” (printed p. 44) addresses professional collaboration and resources.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Fostering a Linguistically Inclusive and Asset-Based Classroom. Open source

The “Helpful Tips” section supports awareness of linguistic diversity, reflection on language and accent biases, shared communicative responsibility and inclusive multilingual participation. Applying this guidance to educator development concerning ethnic-minority languages in Vietnam is a toolkit adaptation.

Galloway, N. (Ed.). (2020). English in higher education – English medium. Part 1: Literature review. British Council. Open source

Pages 50–53 distinguish pedagogy, communication skills and English-language skills in educator development, including paraphrasing, classroom interaction and discipline-specific language. These categories inform the guide; they do not validate its development process.

The review often discusses a shared local language. Applying its principles to ethnic-minority languages in Vietnam requires attention to students' actual language repertoires; Vietnamese should not be assumed to be everyone's strongest language.

The six-step development process, distinction between support categories, observation arrangements, example and checklist are toolkit adaptations. Sources support particular principles rather than a validated staff assessment or development model. The guide requires local review and evaluation and does not establish employment or proficiency requirements.